Somerville Happiness Survey Data Dictionary

Background

This is a data dictionary for the Somerville Happiness Survey Responses 2011 – 2025. The dataset contains every question from the 2025 Happiness Survey and applicable historical data from past Happiness Surveys. Visit the Open Data Portal to download data, view the survey instruments, and explore reports. You can also visit somervillema.gov/HappinessSurvey to view interactive visualizations from the 2025 survey and learn more about the survey's history.

General Notes

Question Types: In this dictionary, questions which allow respondents to select multiple options (checkbox) are categorized as "Multiple Select." Questions which allow respondents to choose only one option (radio button) are categorized as "Single Select."

Boolean Columns: Columns ending with ".YN" are Boolean columns (options 1, 0, or blank), typically one per option for Multiple Select questions. They are marked 1 if the option was selected or written in; 0 if the question was answered and the option was not selected; and blank if the question was not answered.

Scale Questions: Each scale question is released as two columns: the text version, ending with ".label" (e.g. "Very Happy") and the numeric version, ending with ".num" (e.g. 5). Some scales were adapted from 10-point to 5-point scales starting in 2023. See "Scale Columns" section for details.

Metadata Columns

ID

Column Name: ID

Data Type: Integer

Description: A unique ID for the row. The first two digits indicate the year the survey was taken. e.g., The survey with ID 1100001 was taken in 2011.

Note: The order of surveys within a year is random and does not relate to the submission order.

Year

Column Name: Year

Data Type: Integer

Description: The year the survey was taken.

Possible Values:

- 2011
- 2013
- 2015
- 2017
- 2019
- 2021
- 2023
- 2025

Survey Method

Column Name: Survey.Method

Data Type: Text

Description: The channel by which the survey was received, paper or online. From 2011 to 2021, all random-sample Happiness Surveys were received on paper. Starting in 2023, residents selected by mail had the option to take the survey online. In 2025, a portion of residents received postcards in the mail rather than paper surveys; these residents had the option to take the survey online or request a paper survey be mailed to them.

Possible Values:

- Paper
- Online

Years Available: All

Survey Language

Column Name: Survey.Language

Data Type: Text

Description: The language the survey was taken in (metadata, not a question on the survey). This data was not collected for every year.

Possible Values:

- English
- Another Language

Years Available: 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Notes:

- 2023 and 2025 offered paper surveys in English, Spanish, Portuguese, and Haitian Creole, with online options for Nepali, Traditional Chinese, and Simplified Chinese.

- For the answer to the question “What languages do you speak at home?” see the “Languages Spoken” column.

Demographics Columns

Gender

Column Name: Gender

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Man
- Nonbinary
- Woman
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2023, 2025	Multiple Select	What is your gender? Check all that apply. ☐ Man ☐ Nonbinary ☐ Woman ☐ Prefer not to answer ☐ Prefer to self-describe: _____
2017, 2019, 2021	Single Select	What is your gender? ○ Female ○ Male ○ Other _____
2013, 2015	Single Select	What is your sex? ○ Male ○ Female
2011	Open Text	What is your gender? (M/F)

Notes:

- People who specified a nonbinary gender such as “nonbinary” or “genderqueer” were coded as “nonbinary.” This includes people who selected or wrote a nonbinary gender *and* another gender.

- People who indicated a binary gender and were trans (e.g. “trans man”) were coded with the appropriate binary gender (“trans man” => “man”).
- People who checked off both male and female (and did not indicate a nonbinary gender) and/or wrote in something like “A couple filled this out” were coded as NA.

Years Available: All

Age

Column Name: Age

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- 17 or younger
- 18 to 24
- 25 to 34
- 35 to 44
- 45 to 54
- 55 to 64
- 65 to 74
- 75 or older
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2023 (online), 2025 (online)	Single Select	What is your age? ○ 17 or under ○ 18 to 24 ○ 25 to 34 ○ 35 to 44 ○ 45 to 54 ○ 55 to 64 ○ 65 to 74 ○ 75 or over ○ Prefer not to answer
2019, 2021, 2023 (paper), 2025 (paper)	Open Text	What is your age?
2013, 2015, 2017	Single Select	Age? ○ 18-24 ○ 25-34 ○ 35-44

		○ 45-54 ○ 55-64 ○ 65-74 ○ 75 or older
2011	Open Text	Age? Note: Although this was an open text question, the raw data categorizes after the fact into the following categories: • 18-21 • 22-25 • 26-30 • 31-40 • 41-50 • 51-60 • 61 or older

Notes:

- All interpretable open text results have been assigned to one of the categories.
- Where previous age buckets did not fall entirely into one 2025 bucket, the Age has been imputed within the bucket from the distribution of age in Somerville to allow year over year comparison of the same buckets.

Years Available: All

Race & Ethnicity

Column Name: Race.Ethnicity

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Asian or Pacific Islander
- Black or African American
- Hispanic or Latino
- White
- Another race
- Two or more races
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2023, 2025	Multiple Select	What is your race or ethnicity? Check all that apply.

		☐ American Indian or Alaska Native ☐ Asian ☐ Black or African American ☐ Hispanic or Latino ☐ Middle Eastern or North African ☐ Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander ☐ White ☐ Self-describe: _____ ☐ Prefer not to answer
2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	Multiple Select	What is your race or ethnicity? (check all that apply) ☐ Asian ☐ Black/African American ☐ Hispanic/Latino ☐ White ☐ Other
2013	Combination of two questions, Multiple Select and Single Select	What is your race? (check all that apply) ☐ White ☐ Black/African American ☐ Asian Are you of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin? ○ Yes ○ No
2011	Open Text	What is your ethnicity?

Years Available: All

Notes:

- Although this question is asked as a checkbox with multiple options available, this summary column is designed to give the best possible single descriptor of the respondent's race or ethnicity that matches the categories in the U.S. Census, for comparison of demographics to other sources.
- To match the Census, where Hispanic/Latino was chosen (even if other options were chosen), race/ethnicity is given as "Hispanic or Latino." In other cases, when two or more options were chosen, the value is "Two or more races."
- While the Census presently separates "Asian" and "Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander," we grouped Asian and Pacific Islander because the standalone Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander response category is too small to report separately.
- We coded respondents who chose "Middle Eastern or North African" as White to match the Census, because the standalone Middle Eastern and North African response category is too small to report separately.

- Other groups with response categories too small to report separately, including write-ins that don't fall into one of the existing categories, are coded as "Another race."
- In 2013, Hispanic/Latino was determined from a separate question. Write-in responses to this question were not used to otherwise code race. For 2015 and later years, write-in responses were also used to determine Hispanic/Latino. We used the Census definition of Hispanic/Latino (per technical documentation), with the additional inclusion of Brazilian as Hispanic/Latino.

Housing Status

Column Name: Housing.Status

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Own
- Rent
- Other
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025	Single Select	What is your housing status in Somerville? ○ Own ○ Rent ○ Temporary or unstable housing ○ Other: _____ ○ Prefer not to answer
2023	Single Select	What is your housing status in Somerville? ○ Own ○ Rent ○ Temporary or unstable housing ○ Other: _____
2011, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	Single Select	Describe your housing status in Somerville. ○ Own ○ Rent ○ Other (specify): _____

Notes:

- Respondents who selected "Temporary or unstable housing" in 2023 and 2025 were categorized as "Other" because the standalone response category is too small to report separately.
- This question was not asked in 2013.

Years Available: 2011, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Tenure in Somerville

Column Name: Tenure

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Less than 1 year
- 1 to 3 years
- 4 to 7 years
- 8 to 10 years
- 11 to 15 years
- 16 to 20 years
- 21 years or more
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025 (online)	Single Select	How long have you lived in Somerville? ○ Less than 1 year ○ 1 to 3 years ○ 4 to 7 years ○ 8 to 10 years ○ 11 to 15 years ○ 16 to 20 years ○ 21 years or more ○ Prefer not to answer
2011, 2019, 2021, 2023 (paper), 2025 (paper)	Open Text	How long have you lived in Somerville? _____
2013, 2015, 2017, 2023 (online)	Single Select	How long have you lived in Somerville? ○ Less than 1 year ○ 1-3 years ○ 4-7 years

		○ 8-10 years ○ 11-15 years ○ 16-20 years ○ 21 years or more ○ I don't live in Somerville ○ Prefer not to answer

Notes:

- Open text responses have been coded to one of the available categories.

Years Available: All

Transportation

Column Name: Multiple Boolean columns:

- Transportation.Bicycle.YN
- Transportation.Car.YN
- Transportation.Public.Transit.YN
- Transportation.Rideshare.YN
- Transportation.Walk.YN
- Transportation.Other.YN
- Transportation.Prefer.Not.To.Answer.YN

Data Type: Boolean

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025	Multiple Select	In the past week, which of the following transportation options did you use? (Check all that apply.) ☐ Bicycle ☐ Car ☐ Public transit ☐ Rideshare or taxi ☐ Walk ☐ Other: _____ ☐ Prefer not to answer
2023	Multiple Select	In the past week, which of the following transportation options did you use? (Check all that apply.) ☐ Bicycle ☐ Car ☐ Public transit ☐ Rideshare or taxi

		☐ Walk ☐ Other (specify): _____
2019	Multiple Select	Which of the following have you used in the past month to get around? ☐ Walk ☐ Bike ☐ Public transit ☐ Car

Years Available: 2019, 2023, 2025

Notes:

- While the wording changed from "in the past month" in 2019 to "in the past week" in 2023 and 2025, responses were similar enough for the questions to be combined in the dataset.
- Rideshare or taxi was not an option in 2019.
- If Prefer Not to Answer was selected, all other answers were blanked.

Describe Yourself

Column Name: Multiple Boolean columns:

- Children.YN
- Cultural.Religious.Minority.YN
- Disability.YN
- Neurodivergent.YN
- Immigrant.YN
- LGBTQIA.YN
- Student.YN
- Veteran.YN
- Describe.Yourself.Prefer.Not.To.Answer.YN

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2023, 2025	Multiple Select	How would you describe yourself? Check all that apply. ☐ Cultural or religious minority ☐ Immigrant ☐ LGBTQIA+ ☐ Parent/guardian of children under 18 ☐ Person with disabilities ☐ Veteran ☐ Student ☐ None of these

		☐ Prefer not to answer ☐ Prefer to self-describe: _____
2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	Single Select	Do you have children age 18 or younger who live with you? ○ Yes ○ No
2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	Single Select	Are you a student? ○ Yes ○ No
2021	Single Select	Do you identify as having a disability and/or physical impairment that substantially limits one or more of your major life activities? ○ Yes ○ No

Notes:

- Note that in years prior to 2023, only some of these concepts were asked as separate questions.
- "Children.YN" refers to "parent/guardian of children under 18" or "do you have children age 18 or younger who live with you?"
- If the respondent selected "Prefer not to answer," all other answers were blanked, even if other options were checked. If the respondent chose "None of these," all other answers were made 0.
- The column Veteran.YN refers to the "Veteran" option in the Describe Yourself question. For the 2025 question about whether a respondent has any veterans in their household, see the "Veterans in Household" column.

Years Available: 2021 (disability), 2013-2021 (children), 2013-2021 (student), 2023 (all but neurodivergent), 2025 (all)

Difficulty Paying

Column Name: Multiple Boolean columns:

- Difficulty.Paying.YN
- Difficulty.Paying.Food.YN
- Difficulty.Paying.Housing.YN
- Difficulty.Paying.Healthcare.YN
- Difficulty.Paying.Utilities.YN
- Difficulty.Paying.Other.YN
- Difficulty.Paying.Prefer.Not.To.Answer.YN

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025	Multiple Select	In the past month, have you had difficulty paying for any of the following? (Check all that apply.) ☐ Food ☐ Housing ☐ Healthcare ☐ Utilities ☐ None of these ☐ Other: _____ ☐ Prefer not to answer
2023	Multiple Select	In the past month, have you had difficulty paying for any of the following? (Check all that apply.) ☐ Food ☐ Housing ☐ Utilities ☐ None ☐ Other: _____

Notes:

- Difficulty.Paying.YN is a rollup column: respondents are marked with 1 if they indicated having difficulty paying for any option (including Other), and 0 if they indicated None.
- If Prefer Not to Answer was selected, all other answers were blanked.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Education

Column Name: Highest.Level.Education

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Some school
- High school diploma or GED
- College degree (e.g., associate's or bachelor's)
- Master's degree or higher
- Other
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025	Single Select	What is your highest level of education? ○ Some school ○ High school diploma or GED ○ College degree (e.g. associate's or bachelor's) ○ Master's degree or higher ○ Other: _____ ○ Prefer not to answer

Years Available: 2025

Household Size

Household Size

Column Name: Household.Size

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- 1 person
- 2 people
- 3 people
- 4 people
- 5 people
- 6 or more people
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2023 (paper)	Open Text	How many.... people are in your household? _____
2023 (online)	Single Select	How many people are in your household? ○ 1 person ○ 2 people ○ 3 people ○ 4 people ○ 5 people ○ 6 or more people

		○ Other: _____

Notes:

- Open text responses have been coded to one of the available categories.
- Household.Size is calculated by adding Adults.In.Household and Children.In.Household in 2025.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Adults in Household

Column Name: Adults.In.Household

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- 1 adult
- 2 adults
- 3 adults
- 4 adults
- 5 adults
- 6 or more adults
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025 (paper)	Open Text	How many.... adults (18+) are in your household? _____
2025 (online)	Single Select	How many adults (18+) are in your household? ○ 1 adult ○ 2 adults ○ 3 adults ○ 4 adults ○ 5 adults ○ 6 or more adults ○ Prefer not to answer

Years Available: 2025

Notes:

- Open text responses have been coded to one of the available categories.

Children in Household

Column Name: Children.In.Household

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- 0 children
- 1 child
- 2 children
- 3 children
- 4 children
- 5 children
- 6 or more children
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025 (paper)	Open Text	How many.... children under 18 are in your household? _____
2025 (online)	Single Select	How many children under 18 are in your household? ○ 0 children ○ 1 child ○ 2 children ○ 3 children ○ 4 children ○ 5 children ○ 6 or more children ○ Prefer not to answer

Years Available: 2025

Notes:

- Open text responses have been coded to one of the available categories.

Veterans in Household

Column Name: Veterans.In.Household

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Yes

- No
- Not sure
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025	Single Select	Are there any veterans in your household? ○ Yes ○ No ○ Not sure ○ Prefer not to answer

Years Available: 2025

Bedrooms

Column Name: Bedrooms

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- 0 bedrooms (e.g., studio)
- 1 bedroom
- 2 bedrooms
- 3 bedrooms
- 4 bedrooms
- 5 or more bedrooms
- Does not apply
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2023 (paper), 2025 (paper)	Open Text	How many.... bedrooms are in your unit? _____
2023 (paper), 2025 (online)	Single Select	How many bedrooms are in your unit? ○ 0 bedrooms (e.g., studio) ○ 1 bedroom ○ 2 bedrooms ○ 3 bedrooms ○ 4 bedrooms

		○ 5 or more bedrooms ○ Does not apply ○ Prefer not to answer

Notes:

- Open text responses have been coded to one of the available categories.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Cars

Column Name: Cars

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- 0 cars
- 1 cars
- 2 cars
- 3 cars
- 4 cars
- 5 or more cars
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025 (paper)	Open Text	How many.... cars does your household own or lease? _____
2025 (online)	Single Select	How many cars does your household own or lease? ○ 0 cars ○ 1 cars ○ 2 cars ○ 3 cars ○ 4 cars ○ 5 or more cars ○ Prefer not to answer
2023 (paper)	Open Text	How many.... cars does your household own? _____
2023 (online)	Single Select	How many cars does your household own? ○ 0 cars ○ 1 cars

		○ 2 cars ○ 3 cars ○ 4 cars ○ 5 or more cars

Notes:

- Open text responses have been coded to one of the available categories.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Household Income

Household Income

Column Name: Household.Income

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- Less than $25,000
- $25,000 to $49,999
- $50,000 to $74,999
- $75,000 to $99,999
- $100,000 to $149,999
- $150,000 to $199,999
- $200,000 or more
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025	Single Select	What is the approximate annual income of your household? ○ Less than $25,000 ○ $25,000 to $49,999 ○ $50,000 to $74,999 ○ $75,000 to $99,999 ○ $100,000 to $149,999 ○ $150,000 to $199,999 ○ $200,000 or more ○ Prefer not to answer
2023 (paper)	Open Text	What is the approximate annual income of your household?
2023 (online)	Single Select	What is the approximate annual income of your household? ○ Less than $10,000 ○ $10,000 to $24,999

		○ $25,000 to $49,999 ○ $50,000 to $74,999 ○ $75,000 to $99,999 ○ $100,000 to $149,999 ○ $150,000 to $199,999 ○ $200,000 or more ○ Prefer not to answer
2019, 2021	Single Select	What is your annual household income? ○ Less than $10,000 ○ $10,000 to $24,999 ○ $25,000 to $49,999 ○ $50,000 to $74,999 ○ $75,000 to $99,999 ○ $100,000 to $149,999 ○ $150,000 to $199,999 ○ $200,000 or more
2013, 2015, 2017	Single Select	What is your annual household income? ○ Less than $10,000 ○ $10,000 to $24,999 ○ $25,000 to $49,999 ○ $50,000 to $74,999 ○ $75,000 to $99,999 ○ $100,000 to $149,999 ○ $150,000 or more
2011	Open Text	What is your annual household income?

Notes:

- Write-in values have been assigned to a range.
- For every response that indicated a range, household income has been imputed within the range from the ACS distribution of household income in Somerville to allow for inflation adjustment. Imputed incomes were inflation-adjusted to 2025 dollars using the CPI inflation number (Inflation.Adjustment) and mapped to a current year bucket.

Years Available: All

Likely Low Income

Column Name: Likely.Low.Income

Data Type: Boolean

Notes: A flag identifying respondents whose reported income and/or income per number in household are low-income (less than 60% of median income).

- 1 if the household income per number in household is less than 60% of the Somerville median income divided by Somerville average household size in the given year (see "ACS.Somerville.Median.Income" and "ACS.Somerville.Avg.Household.Size"). If household size is unknown it is assumed to be 1 (the lowest possible).
- 0 if household income and number of people in household are known, but over the cutoff.
- Null if not enough information exists to make an assessment.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Rent or Mortgage

Rent or Mortgage

Column Name: Rent.Mortgage

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- No rent or mortgage
- Less than $1,000 per month
- $1,000 to $1,499 per month
- $1,500 to $1,999 per month
- $2,000 to $2,499 per month
- $2,500 to $2,999 per month
- $3,000 to $3,499 per month
- $3,500 to $3,999 per month
- $4,000 to $4,499 per month
- $4,500 per month or higher
- Prefer not to answer

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2025 (online)	Single Select	What is the monthly cost of your household's rent or mortgage? ○ No rent or mortgage ○ Less than $1,000 per month ○ $1,000 to $1,499 per month ○ $1,500 to $1,999 per month ○ $2,000 to $2,499 per month ○ $2,500 to $2,999 per month ○ $3,000 to $3,499 per month ○ $3,500 to $3,999 per month ○ $4,000 to $4,499 per month ○ $4,500 per month or higher

		○ Prefer not to answer
2023, 2025 (paper)	Open Text	What is the monthly cost of your household's rent or mortgage?

Notes:

- Write-in values have been assigned to a range.
- For every response that indicated a range, rent or mortgage has been imputed within the range from the ACS distribution of rent or mortgage in Somerville to allow for inflation adjustment. Imputed rent/mortgages were inflation-adjusted to 2025 dollars using the CPI inflation number (Inflation.Adjustment) and mapped to a current year bucket.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Likely Cost Burdened

Column Name: Likely.Cost.Burdened

Data Type: Boolean

Notes: A flag identifying respondents who are cost-burdened.

- 1 if the respondent pays more than 30% of their income in rent (i.e., given or imputed inflation-adjusted Rent.Mortgage divided by given or imputed inflation-adjusted Household.Income is greater than 0.3)
- 1 if the respondent reported "Difficulty.Paying" for anything (other than "None")
- 0 if Difficulty.Paying, Rent.Mortgage, and Household.Income are known, but do not meet qualifications above
- Null if not enough information exists to make an assessment.

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Language Spoken

Column Name: Language.Spoken

Data Type: Text

Possible Values:

- English only
- English and other language(s)
- Non-English language(s) only

Question Type/Question Text:

Year	Question Type	Question Text
2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025	Open text	What language(s) do you speak at home?

Notes: Write-in values are assigned to a value based on whether the respondent indicated they speak only English at home, English and at least one other language at home, or only (a) non-English language(s) at home. The language in which the survey was taken (Survey.Language) does not impact Language.Spoken.

Years Available: 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Tract

Column Name: Tract

Data Type: Text

Description: The tract (census area) in which the respondent lives.

Notes:

- Tract is determined from the block code to which the survey was mailed.
- A census geographic identifier is made up of 3 components in the following hierarchical order: State Code, County Code, Tract Code. For example, the tract ID “250173501061010” is made up of those 3 components from left to right. Therefore, "250" is the State Code, "17" is the County Code, and the remaining "3501061010" is the Tract Code. The Tract value is a unique identifier for each census area in which the respondent lives.

Years Available: 2025

Ward

Column Name: Ward

Data Type: Text

Description: The ward (electoral district) in which the respondent lives.

Possible Values: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7

Notes: Ward is determined from a respondent’s address, neighborhood, or block code, depending on the survey year, typically indicated by identifiers on the paper survey or in the URL.

Years Available: 2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Scale Questions

Background

Scale questions are ordered multiple-choice questions such as “How happy are you right now?” with the ordered options “Very Unhappy” (1), “Unhappy” (2), “Neutral” (3), “Happy” (4), and “Very Happy” (5). Scale questions make up the majority of questions on the Happiness Survey.

Each scale question results in two columns in the data. Happiness, for example:

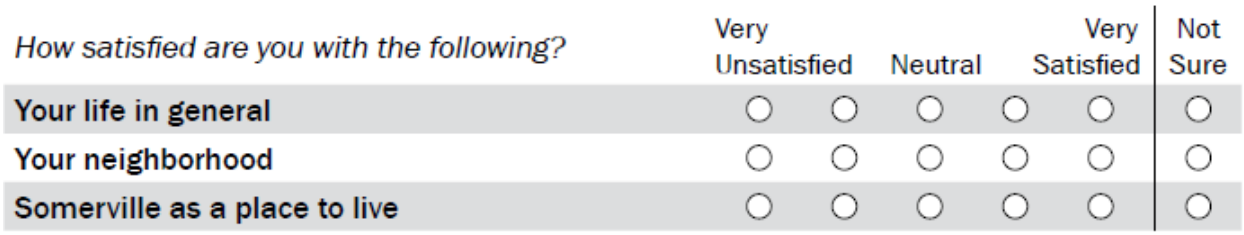
- **Happiness.label** – text version of the response, e.g. “Very Happy”
- **Happiness.num** – numeric version of the response, e.g. 5

All scales are 5-point scales, except for “Concern” which is a 3-point scale (“Not Concerned” (1), “Concerned” (2), and “Very Concerned” (3)).

Before 2023, some questions were asked on a 10-point scale. These have been converted to 5-point scales for consistency with 2023 and 2025 surveys. After studying how people use both scales, we used the following conversion:

10-Point Scale	5-Point Scale
1	1
2, 3	2
4, 5, 6	3
7, 8	4
9, 10	5

Starting in 2023, scale questions were presented as multiple-choice, typically in a matrix format. The 2023 and 2025 surveys also introduce the option “Not Sure” for most scale questions.



How satisfied are you with the following?	Very Unsatisfied		Neutral		Very Satisfied	Not Sure
Your life in general	○	○	○	○	○	○
Your neighborhood	○	○	○	○	○	○
Somerville as a place to live	○	○	○	○	○	○

Figure 1. Matrix question in 2023 paper survey.

Prior surveys showed vertical blanks where users were to check off the position of their response.

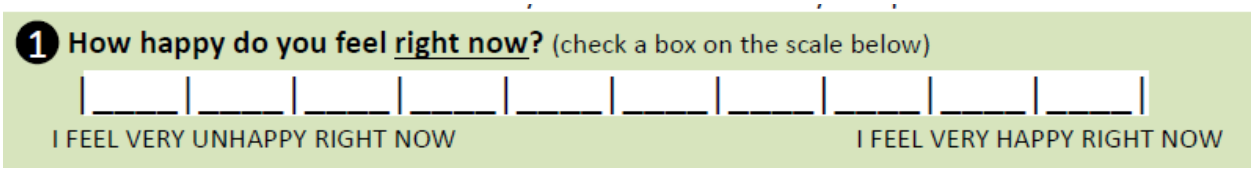


Figure 2. Scale question on 2021 survey.

Occasionally users wrote in half-values in this style; these have been rounded to whole values.

The following scales are possible in the data:

Happiness Scale (5-point)

Label	Num
Very Unhappy	1
Unhappy	2
Neutral	3
Happy	4
Very Happy	5

Satisfaction Scale (5-point)

Label	Num
Very Unsatisfied	1
Unsatisfied	2
Neutral	3
Satisfied	4
Very Satisfied	5
Not Sure	

Concern Scale (3-point)

Label	Num
Not Concerned	1
Concerned	2
Very Concerned	3
Not Sure	

Agreement Scale (5-point)

Label	Num
Strongly Disagree	1
Disagree	2
Neutral	3
Agree	4
Strongly Agree	5
Not Sure	

Note that “Not Sure” responses map to blank numeric results, so looking at just the number column, it’s not possible to tell whether the questions were skipped. Look to the label for meaningful nulls. However, it’s safe to use the .num column for averages, medians, etc. because non-responses are already filtered out.

Happiness & General Satisfaction

Happiness

Question Text: How happy do you feel right now?

Scale: Happiness

Years Available: All

Life.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with your life in general?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: All

Somerville.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025	How satisfied are you with Somerville as a place to live?
2011	Taking everything into account, how satisfied are you with Somerville as a place to live?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: All

Neighbors.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with your relationships with your neighbors?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Feel.Part.Community

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? I feel like I am part of the Somerville community

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

Feel.Safe.Somerville

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? I feel safe in Somerville

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

Community and Governance

Different.Backgrounds.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with opportunities in Somerville to interact with people of different backgrounds and life experiences?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Civic.Participation.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with opportunities for civic participation (e.g., community meetings, Participatory Budgeting, boards and commissions)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Heard.By.City

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? I feel heard by my City government

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

City.Processes.Visible

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? City government processes are visible and understandable to me

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

Information.Vote

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? I have the information I need to vote in Somerville's local elections

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

Health & Housing

Basic.Needs.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with your ability to access food, clothing, shelter, and other basic needs?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Housing.Condition.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the condition of your housing?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Housing.Options.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the quality and variety of housing options available to you within your budget in Somerville?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Grocery.Access.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with access to your preferred grocery store or market?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Health.Services.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with access to high quality services that support your health and well-being (e.g., medical, mental health, fitness)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Relief.Heat.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with access to relief from extreme heat (e.g., air conditioning, shade, splash pads)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Priced.Out.Concern

Question Text: How concerned are you about being priced out of living in Somerville?

Scale: Concern

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Crossing.Street.Safety.Concern

Question Text: How concerned are you about your safety when crossing a busy street?

Scale: Concern

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Rats.Mice.Concern

Question Text: How concerned are you about the presence of rats and mice?

Scale: Concern

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Air.Pollution.Concern

Question Text: How concerned are you about air pollution in your neighborhood?

Scale: Concern

Years Available: 2025

Public Space and Infrastructure

Beauty.Neighborhood.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2025	How satisfied are you with the beauty, cleanliness, and upkeep of your neighborhood?
2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023	How satisfied are you with the beauty or physical setting of your neighborhood?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Streets.Layout.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the layout and design of streets in your neighborhood?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Getting.Around.Convenience.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2025	How satisfied are you with the convenience of getting where you want to go in Somerville?
2023	How satisfied are you with the convenience of getting where you want to go?

2019, 2021	How convenient is it for you to get where you want to go?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Parks.Proximity.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with your proximity to a park you like or want to use?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Public.Spaces.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with access to other public spaces you enjoy (e.g., libraries, recreational facilities)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Built.Environment.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the quality of the built environment in Somerville (e.g., buildings, streets, sidewalks, sewer systems)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Buildings.Maintenance.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the maintenance of municipal buildings (e.g., City Hall, libraries, schools, public safety buildings)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Streets.Sidewalks.Maintenance.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2025	How satisfied are you with the maintenance of streets, sidewalks, and bike lanes?
2023	How satisfied are you with the maintenance of streets and sidewalks?

2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	How would you rate the following: The maintenance of streets and sidewalks
2013	How would you rate the following: The maintenance of streets, sidewalks, and squares

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Arts & Local Economy

Social.Community.Events.Availability.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2023, 2025	How satisfied are you with social community events (e.g., ArtBeat, PorchFest, SomerStreets)?
2021	How would you rate the following: The availability of social/community events** such as festivals, remote celebrations, and street fairs
2013, 2015, 2017, 2019	How would you rate the following: The availability of social/community events** such as festivals, picnics, parades, and street fairs (e.g. SomerStreets)

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

Enjoy.Create.Art.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with your ability to enjoy and create art in Somerville?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Work.Opportunities.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with your work opportunities in Somerville?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Restaurants.Shops.Businesses.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the restaurants, shops, and other businesses in your neighborhood?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Encourage.Commercial.Development

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? The City should encourage more commercial development to provide tax revenue for City services

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

Repurpose.Street.Parking

Question Text: How much do you agree with the following? The City should repurpose street parking for other public uses (e.g., bike and bus lanes, outdoor dining, parks).

Scale: Agreement

Years Available: 2025

Education

Education.Quality.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2025	How satisfied are you with the following? The quality of education in Somerville
2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	How would you rate the following: The overall quality of public schools
2011	How would you rate the following: The overall quality of public schools in your community

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2011, 2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2025

Note: Data from 2023 was dropped because the question asked about Somerville Public Schools specifically.

Availability.Childcare.0.4.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the availability of childcare for children ages 0–4?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Availability.OST.Care.PK.5.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the availability of out-of-school care for children in grades PK–5?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Availability.OST.Activities.6.8.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the availability of out-of-school activities for youth in grades 6–8?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Availability.OST.Activities.0.12.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the availability of out-of-school activities for youth in grades 9–12?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Youth.Workforce.Readiness.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the City's efforts to support youth workforce readiness and non-college paths?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Adult.Education.Learning.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the availability of adult education and learning opportunities in Somerville?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Core City Services

City.Services.Information.Availability.Satisfaction

Question Text:

Year	Question Text
2023, 2025	How satisfied are you with the availability of information about city services?

2015, 2017, 2019, 2021	How would you rate the following? The availability of information about city services

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025

City.Services.Quality.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the quality of city services you receive (e.g., trash pickup, parking permits)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2023, 2025

Water.Sewer.Reliability.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the reliability of water and sewer services?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

City.Services.Facilities.Accessibility.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the accessibility of City services and facilities (e.g., ADA compliant facilities and programming, auxiliary aids for meetings like CART and ASL)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Emergency.Response.Quality.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the quality of emergency response services in Somerville (e.g., fire, police, ambulance)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Efforts.Decrease.Rats.Mice.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the City's efforts to decrease the presence of rats and mice?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Efforts.Become.More.Modern.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the City's efforts towards becoming a more modern government (e.g., moving processes online, piloting new programs)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Efforts.Reducing.GHG.Emissions.Satisfaction

Question Text: How satisfied are you with the City's efforts towards reducing Somerville's greenhouse gas emissions (e.g., Community Choice Electricity, public electric vehicle charging)?

Scale: Satisfaction

Years Available: 2025

Context Columns

These additional helper columns from outside data sources can be used for context or to create more useful comparisons between different years of data.

Census.Year

The year of American Community Survey data being used in other ACS columns. For historical data, this is the same as the survey year. However, for the most recent year of data, we may use the previous year if newer data is not available.

ACS.Somerville.Median.Income

Median household income from "Income in the Past 12 Months" table (S1901) from American Community Survey.

ACS Year	Median household income (1-Year Estimate)
2011	64,480
2013	67,118
2015	73,106
2017	84,722
2019	97,328
2021	108,896
2023	126,619
2024 (used for 2025)	142,553

Data Type: Numeric

ACS.Somerville.Avg.Household.Size

Average household size from “Households and Families” table (S1101) from American Community Survey.

ACS Year	Average household size (1-Year Estimate)
2011	2.29
2013	2.34
2015	2.43
2017	2.29
2019	2.44
2021	2.19
2023	2.1
2024 (used for 2025)	2.26

Data Type: Numeric

Inflation.Adjustment

The number of dollars each dollar is worth in the most recent year’s dollars. The most recent year of data is always 1. Calculated with the Bureau of Labor Statistics Inflation Calculator, for June of each survey year.

$1 in…	Has the same buying power as what in June 2025?
June 2011	1.43
June 2013	1.38
June 2015	1.35
June 2017	1.32
June 2019	1.26
June 2021	1.19
June 2023	1.06
June 2025	1

Data Type: Numeric